Lesson 28: Grammar: Reported Speech

English Stage 2 (B2) · Unit 3: Verb Tenses and Narration · The Human Lifespan

Adapted from High-Intermediate Academic Grammar for ESL Students by Rebecca Al Haider, Reedley College (CC BY 4.0): 8.4: Grammar Presentation-Direct and Indirect (Reported) Speech; 8.5: Applying Grammar to Reading; 8.6: Communication Practice.

In this lesson

You will learn to report what other people said or wrote: the changes in verb tenses, pronouns, time and place words, *that* or *if*, and *said* or *told*. Then you will find the reporting verbs in "Mirror Stage" (Lesson 27). Academic writers report researchers' ideas all the time, so this grammar helps you summarize sources for your psychology course.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Change direct speech into reported speech, with the correct verb tenses.
- Change pronouns, possessive adjectives, time words and place words.
- Use *that* for statements, *if* or *whether* for yes/no questions and *to* + verb for commands.
- Choose between *say* and *tell*, and avoid mixing "according to" with a reporting verb.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
direct speech	someone's exact words, inside quotation marks	The man said, "I can't come to your party."
reported (indirect) speech	the same information in your own words, without quotation marks	The man said that he couldn't come to my party.
reporting verb	a verb that introduces speech, e.g. say, tell, ask, inquire, reply, state, report, complain, explain, remark, note	Wallon noted that …
tense change	moving the verb one step back into the past in reported speech	"I study hard." → He said that he studied hard.
imperative	a command; it starts with the base verb and has no subject	"Bring your books to class tomorrow."
yes/no question	a question that you answer with yes or no	"Do you want a job?" → He asked if I wanted a job.
direct object	the noun or pronoun that receives the action; after *tell*, the person you speak to	Pedro told Danielle to turn off the lights.

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
according to	a phrase that names the source of an idea, followed by a comma and a complete sentence	According to Claude Steele, stereotype threat affects students' performance.

Rules and explanations

Direct and reported speech

- **Direct speech** repeats the exact words in quotation marks. **Reported speech** gives the same information in your own words; native speakers almost always use it. Subjects, verbs, possessive adjectives (my, his ...) and places change: *My wife told the delivery person, "Put the boxes here." → My wife told the delivery person to put the boxes there.*

Verb tense changes

After a **past** reporting verb (said, told, asked), move the verb back:

Direct speech	Reported: He said (that) he ...	Change
"I study hard."	studied hard.	simple present → simple past
"I am studying hard."	was studying hard.	present progressive → past progressive
"I will study hard."	would study hard.	will → would
"I am going to study hard."	was going to study hard.	am/is/are going to → was/were going to
"I can study hard."	could study hard.	can → could
"I have studied hard."	had studied hard.	present perfect → past perfect
"I studied hard."	had studied hard.	simple past → past perfect

- **No change** after a reporting verb in the simple present, present perfect or simple future: *He says, "I have studied hard." → He says that he has studied hard.* (A present reporting verb usually means you are reporting immediately.)
- **That is optional:** *He said (that) he studied hard.* Native speakers often leave it out.

Pronouns, time words and place words

- I → he/she · you → I/we/she/he/they (it depends who is meant) · my → his/her · our → their · your → my/our
- here → there · now → then · this/these → that/those · today → that day · tomorrow → the next day · yesterday → the day before

Three patterns: that, if, to

- Statement → **that**: *He said that the cake was beautiful.*
- Yes/no question → **if** (or *whether*): *He asked, "Do you want a job?" → He asked if I wanted a job.*
- Command (imperative) → **to** + verb (an infinitive): *He told them, "Do your homework." → He told them to do their homework.* (The book's table also has "He demanded them to stop talking"; this is

not standard English. Use "He told them to stop talking".)

- Question with a question word → the question word: *"How much will it cost?" → I asked how much it would cost*. (More in Lesson 33.)

Said or told?

- **tell** needs a direct object (the person): *Pedro told Danielle to turn off the lights.*
- **say** has no direct object: *Pedro said to turn off the lights.* (*Pedro said to Danielle, "..."* is possible but less common.) So: not ~~He said me~~.

Common error: "according to"

- Correct: *According to Claude Steele, stereotype threat affects students' performance.* (comma, then a complete sentence)
- Correct: *Claude Steele states that stereotype threat affects students' performance.*
- Incorrect: ~~According to Claude Steele states stereotype threat affects students' performance.~~ Do not use "according to" and a reporting verb together.

> **Note for Arabic speakers** - In Arabic, the verb after "said that" usually keeps the tense of the original words. In English, after a past reporting verb, move the verb back: *She said that she was tired* (not ~~She said that she is tired~~).

Practice

1. Exercise 3: Verb changes in reported speech. Choose the correct verb for the reported speech.

1. Alex said, "I will be home in August." → Alex said he _____ be home in August. a) will b) would c) is going to be
2. My sister asked, "Will your son be home in August?" → My sister asked if my son _____ be home in August. a) will b) would c) is going to be
3. I said to my neighbor, "I love to work in my garden." → I said to my neighbor that I _____ to work in my garden. a) love b) loved c) am loving
4. The woman said to her wife, "We have to fix the broken window." → The woman said to her wife that they _____ to fix the broken window. a) have b) has c) had
5. "Boys make a lot of noise," said the tired mother. → The tired mother said that boys _____ a lot of noise. a) make b) made c) have made
6. The boy said to his grandmother, "I love you." → The boy said to his grandmother that he _____ her. a) loves b) loved c) has loved
7. The policeman asked the driver, "Do you have a driver's license?" → The policeman asked the driver if she _____ a driver's license. a) has b) have c) had
8. The teacher told the students, "Bring your books to class tomorrow." → The teacher told the students to _____ their books to class the next day. a) bring b) brought c) bringing
9. The man said, "The boys are playing soccer." → The man said that the boys _____ soccer. a) are playing b) were playing c) played

10. The woman said to her friend, "A plane just flew by at a very low altitude." → The woman said to her friend that a plane _____ by at a very low altitude. a) just flew b) has just flown c) had just flown
11. The teacher said, "You will be successful." → The teacher said that I _____ be successful. a) will b) would c) must

2. Exercise 4: Pronouns, times and places. Choose the best word(s).

1. The man complained to the restaurant manager, "Please make sure these plates are clean." → The man complained to the restaurant manager to make sure _____ plates were clean. a) these b) this c) those
2. The man responded to me, "I'll see you later on tonight." → My mom responded to me that _____ would see _____ later that night. a) I; you b) she; you c) she; me
3. I inquired of the mechanic, "How much will it cost to repair my car?" → I inquired of the mechanic how much it would cost to repair _____ car. a) my b) your c) his
4. The teacher responded to his student's question by saying, "I'm sorry, but I don't know the answer." → The teacher responded to his student's question by saying that _____ was sorry, but _____ didn't know the answer. a) I b) she c) he
5. The worker told his boss, "I can't come to work tomorrow because I have a doctor's appointment." → The worker told her boss that she couldn't come to work _____ because she had a doctor's appointment. a) tomorrow b) the next day c) yesterday
6. Ahmed said, "I will pay the bill now." → Ahmed said that he would pay the bill _____. a) now b) yesterday c) then
7. Aiste asked, "Can I park here?" → Aiste asked if she could park _____. a) here b) anywhere c) there

3. Exercise 5: That or if. Choose a) that or b) if.

1. The boys asked me, "Do you like classical music?" → The boys asked me _____ I liked classical music.
2. The teacher said, "You will not have an exam Friday." → The teacher said _____ we would not have an exam Friday.
3. When the woman saw the price on the coat, she remarked to her friend, "I think you are crazy if you buy that coat at that price." → When the woman saw the price on the coat, she remarked to her friend _____ she thought her friend was crazy if she bought that coat at that price.
4. My classmate asked me, "Will you study in the library after class?" → My classmate asked me _____ I would study in the library after class.
5. The mail carrier said, "I haven't delivered any mail to that house in over a week." → The mail carrier said _____ he hadn't delivered any mail to that house in over a week.
6. The president commented to her staff, "This job is going to give me gray hair!" → The president commented to her staff _____ that job was going to give her gray hair!
7. The student asked the teacher, "Do we have to type our essay?" → The student asked the teacher _____ we had to type our essay.

4. Exercise 6: Said or told. Choose a) said or b) told (item 10: a) say or b) tell).

1. The teacher _____ the students that noun clauses are difficult.
2. The students _____ that they needed a break.
3. The tutor _____ them that she could help at the Learning Center.
4. My son _____ his friend that he wanted to play superheroes.
5. His friend _____ that he wanted to be Iron Man.
6. Hadi _____ that Mariam wanted to be Spider-Man for Halloween.
7. Barbara _____ her daughter not to be late.
8. Her daughter _____ that she would be home before dark.
9. Billy _____ Piper to behave.
10. Piper didn't _____ anything because it's a dog.

5. Exercise 7: Direct to indirect speech. Change the sentences to reported speech. Pay close attention to the verb tenses, pronouns, times and places.

1. Jehona asked, "Can you write in Arabic?"
2. Kaori said, "This is the best ice cream!"
3. Gulmira said, "I may be late."
4. Hui said, "I need to study for the test tomorrow."
5. Lina said, "Copy my notes from yesterday."
6. Dimitri asked me, "Can you help me understand English grammar?!"

6. Exercise 8: Reported speech in the reading. Reread "Mirror Stage" (Lesson 27). Find the reporting verbs and write their base form (for example, *show*): paragraph 1: one verb; paragraph 2: two; paragraph 3: one; paragraph 4: one; paragraph 5: three.

Speak with your tutor

- "Say ten short sentences in direct speech, like: Ali said, 'I am tired.' I will change each one into reported speech. Correct my tenses and pronouns."
- "Words of Wisdom (Exercise 10): pick a word (money, love, friendship, education, war, respect, freedom, success, patience, knowledge). We each say a short quote about it, and I report yours, like: Dasha says that money is life."
- "Ask me three questions about my week. Then I will report your questions and my answers, like: You asked me if I had finished my homework."

Read aloud

In reported speech, *that* is weak: /ðət/. Read each sentence twice, with *that* and without it.

1. The man said that he couldn't come to my party.
2. My sister says that she wants to win the lottery.

3. Claude Steele states that stereotype threat affects students' performance.
4. He said that he would study hard.

Writing task

Write 100 to 150 words that report what Molly Wright said in "How Every Child Can Thrive by Five" (Lesson 27; use the transcript). Name the speaker and the talk in your first sentence. Report at least five of her ideas with different reporting verbs (said, explained, told, noted …), and write one sentence with "According to …,". For a fact that is still true, you may use a present reporting verb with no tense change (*Molly Wright explains that …*).

Self-editing checklist:

1. Does every sentence with her ideas have a reporting verb?
2. After each past reporting verb, did I change the tense (is → was, can → could, will → would)?
3. Did I change the pronouns (I → she, our → their)?
4. Did I use *tell* + a person and *say* without a person?
5. Did I write "According to Molly Wright," with a comma and no reporting verb after it?

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Watch online

- Reported Speech (Noun Clauses in Indirect Speech): https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=mjVznhZn-6Q
- Using 'Say' and 'Tell' with Noun Clauses: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=YyzqwIl5SVI

Answer key

1. Exercise 3 (book): 1 b, 2 b, 3 b, 4 c, 5 b, 6 b, 7 c, 8 a, 9 b, 10 c, 11 b. (Item 5: some speakers keep *make* for a general truth, but this lesson's rule gives *made*.)

2. Exercise 4 (book): 1 c, 2 c, 3 a, 4 c, 5 b, 6 c, 7 c. (Item 2: the direct speech says "The man", but the reported sentence says "My mom", so the answer is she; me. Item 4: *he* in both blanks.)

3. Exercise 5 (book): 1 b, 2 a, 3 a, 4 b, 5 a, 6 a, 7 b.

4. Exercise 6 (book): 1 b, 2 a, 3 b, 4 b, 5 a, 6 a, 7 b, 8 a, 9 b, 10 a.

5. Exercise 7 (*that* is optional in 2 to 4; *whether* is also correct instead of *if*)

1. Jehona asked (me) if I could write in Arabic. (the book's key says "can"; this is a mistake because after a past reporting verb, *can* changes to *could*)
2. Kaori said that that was the best ice cream. (the book's key says "is"; this is a mistake because after a past reporting verb, *is* changes to *was*)
3. Gulmira said that she might be late. (book)
4. Hui said that he needed to study for the test the next day. (book)
5. Lina said to copy her notes from the day before. (book)
6. Dimitri asked me if I could help him understand English grammar. (the book's key says "can"; this is a mistake for the same reason as item 1)

6. Exercise 8 (book): paragraph 1: show; paragraph 2: propose, feel; paragraph 3: claim; paragraph 4: note; paragraph 5: disagree, claim, claim. (*Lacan wrote, "..."* in paragraph 3 introduces direct speech, so it is not counted.)

My notes